

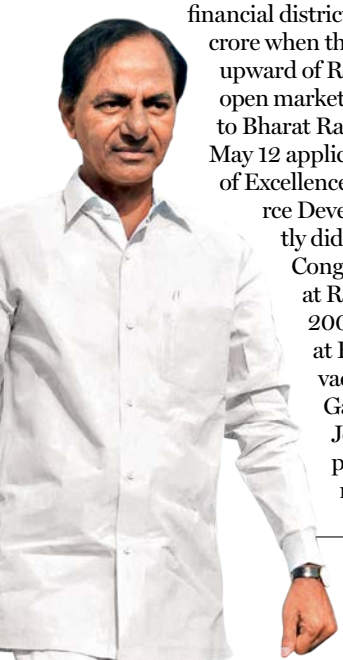
Illustration by SIDDHANT JUMDE

GLASSHOUSE

CONGRESS-YUKT BJP?

Even as the BJP government in Manipur reels under twin crises—ethnic violence and a demand to replace chief minister N. Biren Singh—another rebellion is brewing in neighbouring Tripura. Former CM Biplab Kumar Deb in a presser alleged that "outsiders" and "people with infiltrator mentality" were influencing and weakening the state BJP unit. He was perhaps alluding to Manik Saha, who had joined the BJP only in 2016 but replaced him as CM. In fact, the old BJP faithful in northeastern states constantly complain of imports from other political outfits hijacking the party and ruining its prospects. The four BJP CMs in Assam, Arunachal Pradesh, Manipur and Tripura are all former Congressmen, though Saha claims he was never an official Congress member.

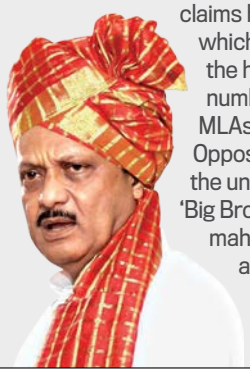
CHEAP STAKES



At the first cabinet meet in the new secretariat on May 18, Telangana chief minister **K. Chandrashekar Rao** virtually gifted 10.5 acres of prime land in Hyderabad's financial district for a mere Rs 37.53 crore when the land parcel costs upward of Rs 550 crore in the open market. This was in response to Bharat Rashtra Samithi's (BRS) May 12 application for an Institute of Excellence and Human Resource Development. Only recently did BRS discover that the Congress gave itself 11 acres at Rs 2 lakh an acre in 2008 for a similar facility at Bowenpally. It's still vacant land, but Rahul Gandhi and his Bharat Jodo Yatra team pitched tents here for a night's stay last year.

Upper Hand

The Congress may have ensured a swashbuckling victory in Karnataka, but its Maha Vikas Aghadi allies in neighbouring Maharashtra are leaving no stone unturned to show who is the boss. Especially the Nationalist Congress Party (NCP), as the Shiv Sena itself is split. NCP leader **Ajit Pawar** claims his party, which has the highest number of MLAs in the Opposition, is the undisputed 'Big Brother'. A maha battle awaits.





ANI

A New EDjective

A decade back, the Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) was called a "caged parrot". Now, Jharkhand chief minister **Hemant Soren** has a new epithet for the Enforcement Directorate (ED). Distributing recruitment letters for high school teachers in Ranchi on May 19, Soren recalled how after Covid, a new epidemic called the ED is stalking the state. Soren has reason to feel sore about the agency, as it questioned him for over nine hours in November 2022 and arrested his aide Pankaj Mishra last July for alleged money-laundering.



SLEEPY HEADS

Looks like Gujarat administrators are sleep-deprived. In April, Bhuj Municipality chief officer **Jigar Patel** lost his job after he was found napping during CM Bhupendra Patel's speech at an event. Then, the cameras zoomed in on Praful Pansheriya, the MoS for education, sleeping at the Chintan Shibir in Kevadiya. More recently, a videographer captured cabinet minister Kunvarji Bavaliya dozing while organisation general secretary Ratnakar was speaking at the BJP executive body meet in Gandhinagar.

Kaushik Deka with Amarnath K. Menon, Dhaval Kulkarni, Amitabh Srivastava and Jumana Shah